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Prompt [2]

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Hume Versus Kant on Synthetic *A Priori* Knowledge

Immanuel Kant argues against David Hume for the existence of synthetic *a priori* knowledge in his 1781 book *Critique of Pure Reason* and his following 1783 book *Prolegomena to Any Future Metaphysics*. Hume, an empiricist, denies the possibility of synthetic *a priori* knowledge; that is, knowledge which does not stem from any experience but is found innately. I seek to reconstruct Hume's argument through the premises that support it, and then reconstruct Kant's argument and elaborate further on the objections it raises against Hume. First, I will define the Kantian term of synthetic *a priori* knowledge, as well as other terms in Kant's prolegomena. I will follow this by iterating over the definitions for impressions and ideas in Hume's Copy Principle. Then, I will reconstruct Hume's argument as to why synthetic *a priori* knowledge cannot exist. Next, I will reconstruct Kant's argument for the existence of synthetic *a priori* knowledge. Finally, I will explore the objections found in Kant's argument in relation to Hume's.

In his prolegomena, Kant divides the logical distinction between judgments into two categories: Analytic and synthetic. These judgments serve a truth functionality. He defines analytic judgments as those which are explicative; that is, knowledge which does not add to a concept but analyzes its universal properties (*Prolegomena, § 2.a*). For example, the concept of a bachelor contains the judgment that "all bachelors are unmarried men" – an analysis of the

universally held concept of bachelors. Analytic judgments are true by definition. The concept of "unmarried man" is contained within the concept of "bachelor" – a particular bachelor does not need to be verified to prove he is unmarried. On the other hand, synthetic judgments are ampliative – they contribute additional knowledge to a concept by combining that concept with another concept (*Prolegomena, § 2.a*). The judgment that "the cat is on the mat" requires the concept of a "cat" to be added to a concept of a "mat" as well as the concept of being "on" something. The truth function of the statement is dependent on observing these concepts together, by observing the cat on the mat. It is true by verification. These distinctions in types of knowledge were critical in Kant's response to Hume's criticisms of modern metaphysics.

In his book, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, David Hume defines impressions and ideas in order to establish a hierarchy between the two that is crucial for his argument. Impressions are direct sensations that are received from the senses, such as seeing an object, as well as the emotions and sentiments experienced as a result of the senses (*An Enquiry* II). Ideas are based on impressions, and more complex ideas are based on simpler ideas (*An Enquiry* II). For example, even though I have never seen a chair made out of cats, I can have an idea of it because I have the idea of a chair, based on the impression of seeing a chair, and the idea of cats, based on the impression of seeing cats, and I can combine these simpler ideas into the more complex one. This is Hume's Copy Principle and it is how he ultimately concludes that all knowledge must be derived, at its very core, from experience. Hume also bolsters his argument by comparing synthetic truths to analytic truths. Analytic truths can only supply a small quantity of information. The truth "a bachelor is an unmarried male" is a tautology and is equivalent logically to "a = a." Although it has truth functionality, it supplies very little information and is basically meaningless. Synthetic truths, however, supply greater amounts of

information. “The cat is on the mat” delivers more than a single point of information and is meaningful. This gives greater value to observational truths.

Hume concludes that there cannot be any synthetic *a priori* knowledge. This is Hume’s ultimate skeptical interpretation of knowledge, his strongest empiricism. His argument is the following:

1. All knowledge comes from impressions or ideas.
2. The validity of synthetic propositions is dependent on experience and involves combining concepts not contained within each other.
3. *A priori* knowledge is knowledge independent of experience and is based only on relationships between ideas.

C. Synthetic *a priori* knowledge is impossible because synthetic propositions are dependent on experience and *a priori* knowledge is knowledge independent of experience.

The argument presented by Hume is valid. If X must depend on Z by definition and Y must not depend on Z by definition, then X and Y cannot be used in conjunction with each other because they have contradictory definitions. Hume employs this reasoning in his construction of “Hume’s Fork.” Hume’s Fork dictates that all synthetic claims are *a posteriori* and all analytic claims are *a priori*. Synthetic claims are dependent on validation and experience, and *a posteriori* knowledge is dependent on experience. Analytic claims are true by definition and require no experience, and *a priori* knowledge is independent of experience. Any swapping of the terms, such as analytic *a posteriori* knowledge or synthetic *a priori* knowledge is contradictory.

Kant argues that *a priori* knowledge can also be synthetic and the two are not mutually exclusive. He deduces that Hume has missed a third area of knowledge. Kant reasons for the

existence of synthetic *a priori* knowledge, a category not included in Hume's Fork. His argument is the following:

1. *A priori* knowledge is possible.
2. Synthetic knowledge is possible.
3. Some *a priori* knowledge requires synthetic verification to arrive at, such as the knowledge that "7+5=12." This knowledge is *a priori* as a mathematical truth, but requires the combination of the concepts of "7+5," and "12" which are not contained within each other.

C. Synthetic *a priori* knowledge is possible.

Kant's argument does not seem valid at first, but it is verifiable. Kant considers mathematics in his argument because Hume classifies mathematical knowledge as *a priori*. Kant proposes that mathematical judgements are synthetic by definition because they are ampliative (*Prolegomena 2.c.1)*. For example, the concept "7+5" does not contain the concept of "12," but the concept of "12" is added to the knowledge of "7+5" by synthetic means, such as envisioning a number of points or counting stones. Nowhere in "7" or "5" or "7+5" does "12" exist until verified synthetically. By this one reclassification of knowledge, Kant categorizes not only mathematics into this third body of knowledge, but also metaphysics.

Kant used this third category to rescue metaphysics from Hume's skepticism. Hume's position on knowledge, especially metaphysics, was epistemological skepticism. Hume supported this position by arguing against the certainty of the natural ways that the mind associates ideas. His most influential skepticism regards the uncertainty of causality. Hume argued that assuming the existence of causality is an assertion that we make about our universe that goes beyond the information our sense organs supply to us. In other words, it was synthetic

knowledge that metaphysicians assumed to be *a priori*. They thought that it was universally given that all effects must have a cause. Hume disagreed for two reasons. The first is that some "Matters of Fact," or synthetic *a posteriori* knowledge, seem to rely on cyclical reasoning. The "Universality of Nature" principle dictates that the future will resemble the past. However, this is only verified by the fact that in the past, the future resembled the past. The second disagreement from Hume is that we assume causality to exist in the first place with no real evidence. For example, in dominoes, we would say that one domino falling causes the next one to fall. However, Hume makes the argument that we do not actually observe this causality, but only that we see one action followed by another. We do not have a sense organ designed to sense causality, so we make a baseless connection between two potentially disconnected actions. All we can deduce *a posteriori* is that one action follows another action.

Kant disagrees with this interpretation of knowledge by Hume. Kant claims that humans have "Categories of Understanding" that are faculties of the mind programmed to interpret the "sense data" of the universe and create meaning. Sense data to Kant is pure intuitions – the pure data observed in the universe. Kant also calls this data from the senses "sensibility" (*Prolegomena 2.c.1)*. These categories are the conditions for the possibility of understanding. Without these categories, sense data such as light waves collected by the eyes would be chaotic and meaningless. When we look at our world, we are not seeing it how it truly is, but rather the map of the world that our mind creates after imposing these *a priori* organizing faculties onto things we are sensing. For example, a red box exists in and of itself as pure data. It is data, not red nor a box. This is what Kant calls "noumenal." My eyes observe the noumenal box and collect data about it. The redness and boxiness of the box, its "phenomenal attributes," are processed and made sense because of the conditions of my mind. The noumenal box is distinct

from its phenomenal attributes because the phenomenal attributes are the only possible way for us to know the box. In this way, Kant argues for the existence of synthetic knowledge coming from experience, such as the observation of the box, as well as *a priori* knowledge within the pre-programmed faculties of my mind. Knowledge is both the *a priori* capabilities of my mind and the synthetic validation of information from sense data. Kant replies that if we lived in Hume's world where all knowledge was based on experience, our knowledge would be meaningless to us because our experience could only supply meaningless sense data. How Kant applies this to Hume's issue with causality is by categorizing causality as another way in which we derive understanding from our universe. He argues that the interpretations of disconnected events are processed by conditions of the mind as part of the universe despite its origins in the mind, just as other sense data is. Disconnected events, such as one action following another, are interpreted by the mind and understood as causal in the same way that certain light waves are understood as a tree or certain frequencies of sound as laughter. In this way, although it is synthetic, causality is also *a priori*.